

News Letter

January Recap

FINANCE FORWARD: WHERE FINANCE MEETS INNOVATION



OPERATION ABSOLUTE RESOLVE: Markets Shocked

On January 3, 2026, U.S. forces captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro in a major military operation, transferring him to the U.S. to face criminal charges. Global markets reacted instantly, with energy stocks surging as Venezuela's oil reserves suddenly appeared open to foreign investment.

Key Takeaway: A single geopolitical move can still shake both governments and markets overnight.



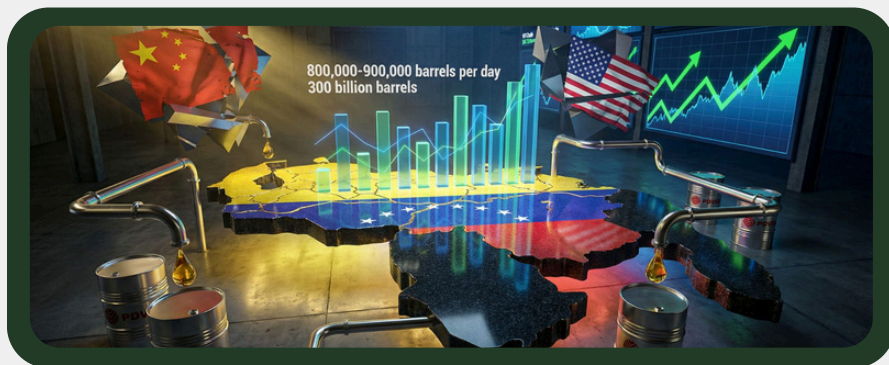
2026: When Markets Blinked First—Money, Markets, and a World Full of Plot Twists

Global markets in early 2026 underscored the fragility of confidence. Geopolitical upheavals, uneven economic signals, and investor anxiety converged to create an arena where risk and opportunity were inseparably intertwined.

The U.S. capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro ignited a surge in energy stocks, buoyed by expectations of renewed oil flows and reconstruction. Yet, uncertainty simultaneously reinforced the appeal of safe-haven assets such as gold and silver. Labor markets proved more resilient than anticipated, but central banks remained circumspect caught between the imperative to tame inflation and the risk of stifling growth.

Investor responses reflected this duality: equities rallied on energy optimism, commodities drew strength from defensive positioning, and policymakers adopted a posture of strategic ambiguity. The year's opening thus became a crucible of resilience, forcing markets to weigh oil against gold, expansion against stability, and policy patience against investor impatience.

Key Takeaway: The trajectory of 2026 hinges on equilibrium. Geopolitics, commodity dynamics, and central bank signaling will continue to recalibrate investor trust, demanding not just vigilance but intellectual agility in navigating complexity.



Zomato's Leadership Shuffle: Strategy Over Speed

Despite rising revenue and a strong stock, Zomato announced a leadership reshuffle. The board's message: shift from "grow at any cost" to "run smarter and profitably." Focus areas: Blinkit, restaurants, logistics. Tighter control aims at stronger long-term margins.

Why it matters: Startups are maturing into serious businesses. Leadership today = survival tomorrow.



India's Startup Boom: 44,000 and Rising

India added a record ~44,000 startups in 2025, marking one of the fastest expansion phases globally. Strong digital infrastructure, UPI-led payments, and government support fueled this surge. Startups are spreading across FinTech, HealthTech, AI, and Climate Tech—especially in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities.

Why it matters: Job creation, innovation, and stronger capital formation across regions.



India's Auto Exports Surge 24% YoY

Auto exports jumped 24% YoY, driven by demand from Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia. Reliable and cost-efficient vehicles, large-scale manufacturing, and policy boosts like PLI powered this surge.

Impact: Smaller trade deficit, more jobs, stronger forex reserves, and a bigger role in global supply chains.

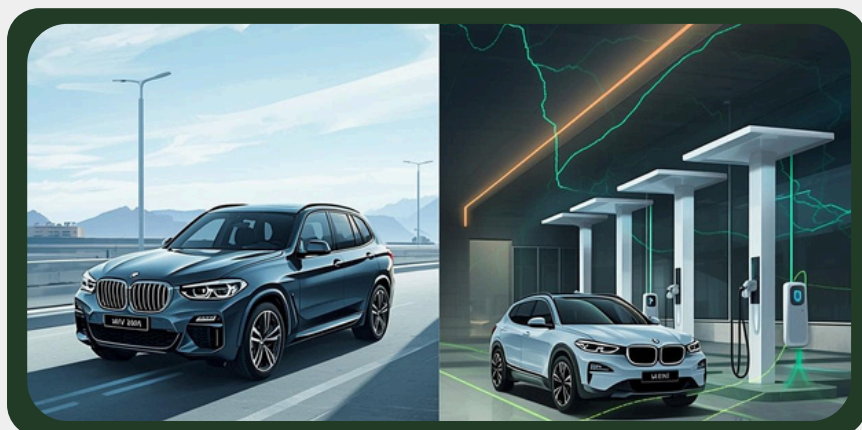


BMW India records highest-ever sales in 2025, driven by SUV growth

2025 was BMW Group India's best year yet, selling 18,001 cars—a 14% jump despite a tough auto market. SUVs powered the surge, with demand rising 22% and accounting for nearly 60% of sales. The BMW X1 led the charts, followed by the X5.

Electric vehicles added another boost: BMW and MINI EV sales jumped over 200%, with 3,753 units sold. EVs now make up 21% of BMW India's sales, with the iX1 emerging as India's top-selling luxury EV.

Key Takeaway: The future of luxury in India is both spacious and electric.

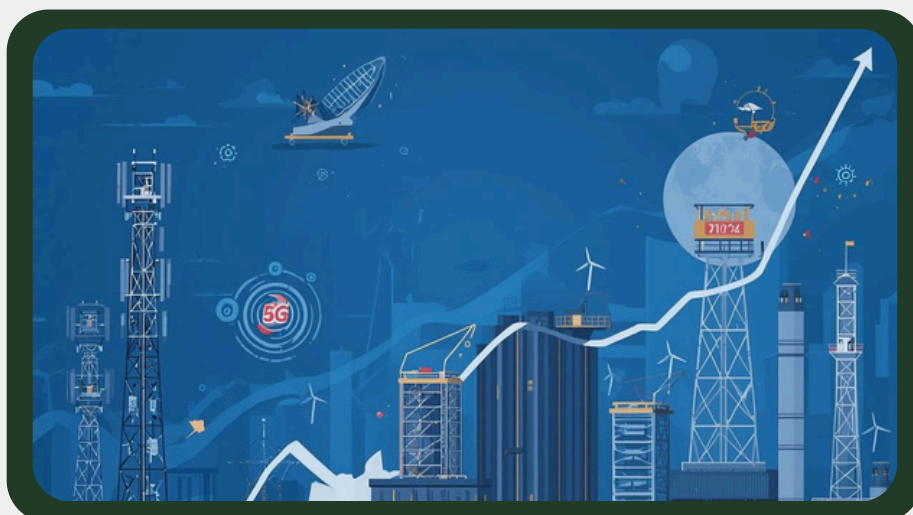


Reliance Q3 Revenue Up 10%: Growth Across Businesses

Reliance Industries posted a ~10% year-on-year rise in Q3 revenue, standing strong despite global uncertainty and volatile commodity prices.

1. Telecom (Jio): More subscribers, higher data usage, improved ARPU, and expanding 5G footprint.
2. Retail: Festive demand, wider store expansion, smoother supply chains.
3. Oil-to-Chemicals: Operational efficiency offset crude price swings.

Impact: Consistent growth boosts investor confidence, mirrors broader economic trends, and funds future bets on renewables, green energy, and new-age tech.



IMF Ups India's FY26 Growth to 7.3%

- **IMF Forecast:** India's FY26 GDP growth raised to 7.3%.
- **Drivers of Optimism:**
 1. Strong consumer demand
 2. Government infrastructure spending
 3. Steady manufacturing growth
- **Impact:**
 1. Faster job creation
 2. Reinforces India's position as the world's fastest-growing major economy



Made in India, Driven Worldwide

India's cars and bikes are traveling more than we are! Auto exports jumped 24% YoY, driven by demand from Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia. Reliable vehicles, large-scale manufacturing, and policy boosts like PLI powered this surge.

Impact: Smaller trade deficit, more jobs, stronger forex reserves, and a bigger role in global supply chains.



COCO Model: Brands in Full Control



The COCO (Company Owned, Company Operated) model lets brands own and run every outlet themselves—no franchise partners, no shared control. From hiring staff to daily operations, the company calls every shot and keeps every rupee of profit.

Why do it? Consistency. Quality. Identity. Premium and flagship brands love the uniform experience it guarantees. The flip side? Heavy upfront costs and full financial risk. Still, for brands where control matters more than convenience, COCO proves that sometimes, doing it all yourself really does pay off.



India's Next Leap: Upper-Middle Income by 2030

India is on track to hit a per capita GNI of ~\$4,000 by 2030, according to SBI research—marking its entry into the upper-middle income group. And when incomes rise, consumption changes.

Spending shifts from basics to cars, appliances, healthcare, education, and entertainment. Urbanization speeds up, new hubs emerge beyond Tier-1 cities, and foreign investors take notice as India edges closer to becoming the world's third-largest economy.

But speed alone isn't enough. To avoid the middle-income trap, India must strengthen education, healthcare, and manufacturing. Growth needs stability, not just momentum.



Republic Day Special: Financial Freedom Today



Freedom isn't just political—it's financial too. For Indian youth in 2026, financial freedom looks like:

- Multiple income streams, not just one salary
- Smart investing before "settling down"
- Less stress, more choices
- Freedom to say yes to dreams and no to bad jobs

Essence: Independence today = choices + security + peace of mind.



India's Auto Industry Accelerates Abroad

Exports of cars and bikes rose 24% YoY, with Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia as key growth markets.

Drivers: Competitive pricing, reliable engineering, manufacturing scale, and policy support like the PLI scheme.

Impact: Strengthens forex reserves, narrows trade deficit, creates jobs, and positions India as a rising force in global supply chains.



SEBI Mutual Funds Regulations 2026: What's Changing & Why It Matters

On January 16, 2026, Securities and Exchange Board of India notified the SEBI (Mutual Funds) Regulations, 2026, replacing the 1996 framework and modernising India's mutual fund regime.

1. Introduction of Base Expense Ratio (BER)

The earlier bundled Total Expense Ratio (TER) masked management fees, broking, and taxes. Under the new framework, investors will clearly see what portion of expenses goes to the AMC versus statutory charges. Lower and more transparent costs improve long-term returns through compounding.

2. Rationalized (Lower) Cost Slabs

Scheme Type	Old Cap (approx.)	New BER Cap (as of 2026)
Index Funds / ETFs	1.00%	0.90%
Equity Schemes (<₹500 Cr)	2.25%	2.10%
Close-ended Equity	1.25%	1.00%
Debt Funds (<₹500 Cr)	2.00%	1.85%

3. Performance-Linked Fees

AMCs may introduce performance-linked BER structures, where fees are linked to returns relative to benchmarks. This aligns fund manager incentives with investor outcomes.

4. MF Lite Framework for Passive Funds

Index funds and ETFs will operate under a simplified regulatory structure with lower compliance burdens. This is expected to reduce costs further and enhance competitiveness in the passive investment segment.

How to use the DIGITAL RUPEE & How it differs from UPI and CRYPTO?



China's viral app reflects shifting demographics with surprising simplicity. Users tap a green button daily to confirm they're safe. Miss check-in for 48 hours, and an emergency contact is alerted.

Morbid name? Maybe. Practical? Definitely. Designed for people living alone, it offers peace of mind without surveillance. No cameras, no trackers, no data collection—its strength lies in how little it does.

By positioning itself as digital reassurance rather than medical tech, the app shows that in an aging society, the most successful innovations aren't about smarter technology, but about more empathy



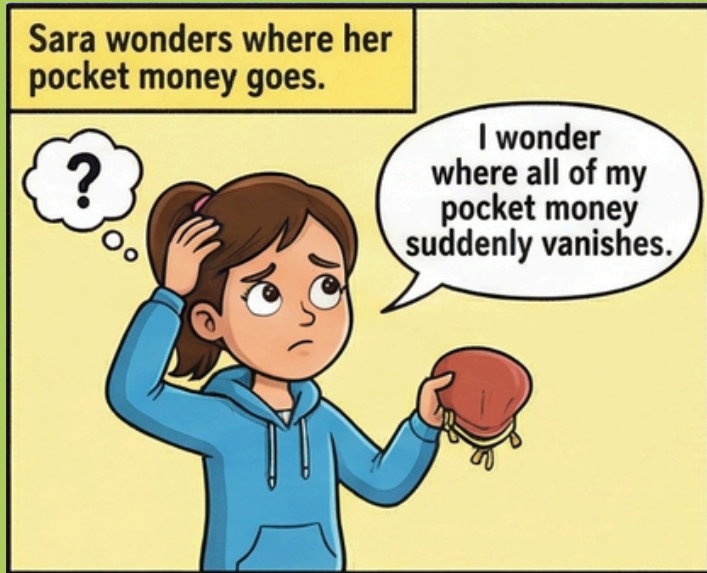
Dhurandhar: Global Blockbuster, Selective Losses

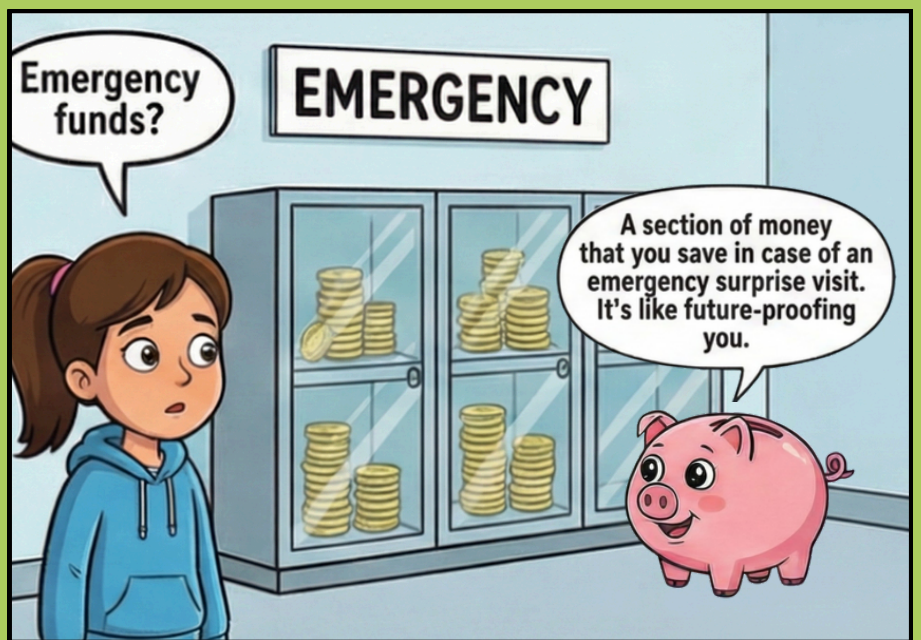
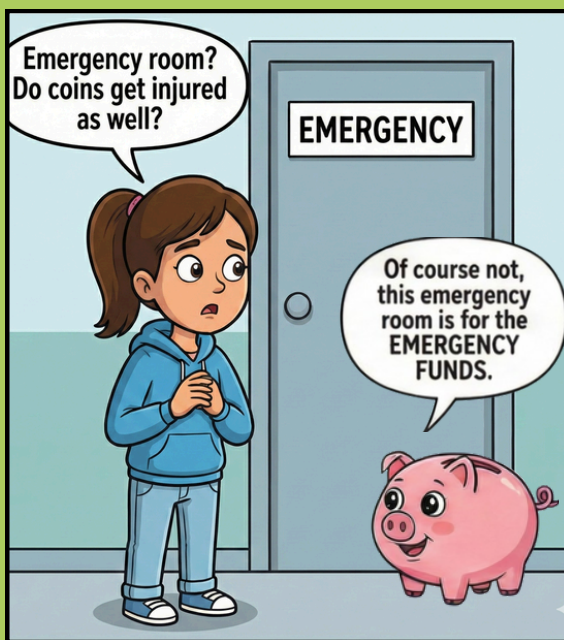


Ranveer Singh's spy thriller Dhurandhar stormed past ₹1,000 crore worldwide, with overseas audiences in North America, Canada, and Australia contributing nearly ₹260–₹290 crore. But bans in Pakistan and several Middle Eastern countries over politically sensitive themes cut off millions in potential revenue. The film's hypernationalist tone sparked debate, showing how politics can still shape box office fortunes. Impact: Despite closed doors in some markets, Dhurandhar remains a clear global hit—proof that Indian cinema can dominate worldwide, even with selective setbacks.

Brokeville

The Mystery of Disappearing Pocket Money





KEY FEATURES AT GLANCE:



- **Markets & Shock:** Geopolitics and commodity moves set a volatile tone; Operation Absolute Resolve jolted energy stocks.
- **India Growth:** IMF lifts FY26 forecast to 7.3%; 44,000 startups added in 2025.
- **Trade & Auto:** Auto exports +24% YoY; BMW posts record year as SUVs and EVs (EVs 21%) surge.
- **Corporate Moves:** Reliance revenue +10%; Zomato shifts from growth-at-all-costs to profitable execution.
- **Regulation:** SEBI 2026 MF rules introduce BER, lower caps, and performance-linked fees.
- **Society & Culture:** China's simple elder-check app shows empathy-driven tech; Dhurandhar crosses ₹1,000 crore despite bans.

Finance



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